DOING PUBLIC HUMANITIES

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Beginning their work with historical photographs of Asian Americans long left out of the public archives, these students were freed to think about other art forms that could be, and have been used, to explore Asian American identity. The use of historical photographs, of building a photographic archive from materials that had been invisible, opened up room for public explorations, in a range of media, of Asian American lives, and culture.

Notes

1 Robert G. Lee, *Orientals: Asian Americans in Popular Culture*, Asian American History and Culture Series (Philadelphia, PA: Temple University Press, 1999).

2 Supreme Court Of The United States. *U.S. Reports: Plessy v. Ferguson, 163 U.S. 537.* 1895. Periodical. https://www.loc.gov/item/usrep163537/. At 561.

3 See for example, Anthony W. Lee, *Picturing Chinatown: Art and Orientalism in San Francisco*, Ahmanson-Murphy Fine Arts Imprint (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 2001) and Anthony W. Lee, *A Shoe-Maker's Story: Being Chiefly about French Canadian Immigrants, Enterprising Photographers, Rascal Yankees, and Chinese Cobblers in a Nineteenth-Century Factory Town* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2008).

4 Anna Pegler-Gordon, *In Sight of America: Photography and the Development of U.S. Immigration Policy*, American Crossroads 28 (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 2009). Elizabeth Sinn, *Pacific Crossing: California Gold, Chinese Migration, and the Making of Hong Kong* (Hong Kong: Hong Kong University Press, 2013).

5 W. Eberhard, "Economic Activities of a Chinese Temple in California," *Journal of the American Oriental Society* 82, no. 3 (1962): 362–71, https://doi.org/10.2307/597647.

6 Maxine Hong Kingston, *The Woman Warrior: Memoirs of a Girlhood among Ghosts* (New York: Vintage Books, 1977).

AFTERWORD: THE "DOING" OF *DOING PUBLIC HUMANITIES*

Matthew Frye Jacobson

A public art installation, a digital exhibition or mapping project, a historic house or a city tour, a commemorative project devoted to histories of violence and struggle, a curatorial project that generates new knowledge from an archive of old family photographs—Public Humanities is in the *doing*. Most of us who have entered Public Humanities from the university side of things—whether faculty or students—have discovered along the way that this is a project whose chief ambitions and whose greatest achievements may be in the realm of form rather than content. We may have each thought at one time that Public Humanities would prove an interesting and expansive vehicle for our intellectual work, that is, but we have learned by the doing that we are not merely disseminating scholarship (as if Public Humanities were merely publication by other means), but evoking a "public" and laying an infrastructure of relationships that is itself a creation of some moment. Public Humanities, properly conducted, is a verb, not a noun.

My own engagement in Public Humanities began as a fluke, continued as a lark, and has ended as the most important gift of my career. What became the Public Humanities program at Yale first bubbled up in the form of student agitation for community engagement and for instruction and technical skills in public intellectual work. This was 2008. The two leaders of this movement, Monica Martinez and Ryan Brasseaux, have gone on to make significant marks in their own right (indeed Martinez, now a professor at Brown, is represented in this volume); but at the time they were both graduate students, and as chair of American Studies it was my good fortune that their terrific ideas were all landing on my desk. We embarked on an inventory of existing resources at Yale, and quickly discovered riches that had gone mostly unnoticed in any systematic way—faculty across the disciplines who had vast experience in Public History, in

exhibition design, in Public Art and archivally-based performance, in filmmaking and other documentary work, in radio, in Digital Humanities, in creative nonfiction, and other forms of "public" writing. We also discovered that the many educators and curators affiliated with the university's collections, museums, and libraries were already conducting tutorials in what could only be called Public Humanities, if a student were savvy enough to find them. The resources were all there, in other words, and we could begin building a record of Public Humanities achievement before we even had to ask the administration for a dime—a strangely important tactic at our wealthy but Puritan institution. My colleague Laura Wexler and I appointed ourselves to the role of acting co-directors (meaning: we *acted like* we were the co-directors, and we still do), and we went to work. As Michael Denning once said, the things most worth doing at a university usually feel like some kind of conspiracy.

The first phase of this stealth program-building consisted of identifying and convening potential stake-holders among faculty, staff, and students, and creating a modest curriculum toward what at most universities would be called a certificate program—not a freestanding degree, but a credential available to students along the way toward their Ph.D. We settled on four requirements that would loosely chart a path for students, but would be open enough to accommodate a wide range of pursuits, documentary filmmaking right alongside museum exhibition or public history. The four requirements included:

1. An Introduction to Public Humanities seminar that is offered each fall. This course theorizes both "publics" and "humanities," and includes introductory readings in museum studies, documentary studies, digital humanities, public and community history, and other dialogic practices in collective knowledge production. The course culminates in a group project each December—a leap of blind faith from one year to the next, but has come to include a truly astonishing array of student accomplishments, including public exhibits devoted to the history of the New Haven waterfront and to the city's music and performance history; a digital project devoted to the local food truck industry and the immigration history that produced it; a three-panel film on the Black Panther trial in New Haven in 1970; a curated public dinner at the New Haven Museum, presenting a global history of local chefs and their cuisines.
2. A "methods" course in one of the skill-based pillars of Public Humanities, such as exhibition design, documentary filmmaking or photography, oral history, pod-casting, or digital humanities.
3. An internship or practicum with a partnering local or regional institution, or with a contiguous unit on campus such as the university's art gallery.
4. A capstone project that may take the form of a traditional academic paper, but is more often an installation or exhibit, a website, a film, a broadcast, a walking tour, an interactive map, or a digital archive.

The establishment of these four requirements in phase one of our collective work led immediately to the more ambitious phase two: the development of our rolodex, as it were, both internally to the university in order to maximize our offerings, and externally across the region, including contacts at historical societies, museums, libraries, documentary production companies, galleries, TV and radio stations, and anywhere else a student might pursue an internship placement. In the years since these initial curricular discussions took place, Public Humanities at Yale has crystalized around six broad areas or modes of research and presentation: Museums & Collections; Documentary Studies; Digital Humanities; History & the Public; Space & Place; and Arts Research. Each area represents one of the nodes of faculty and staff strength we discovered in our inventory; each is also tied to institutional partnerships we have forged over the years. Its chameleon-like quality is one reason that Public Humanities takes such different forms from one institution to the next—centering museum studies at one college, digital humanities or public history at the next—as the enterprise adapts to the particularities of a given institutional and local setting. But this is also one of the great strengths of the field, keeping it both nimble but ever on-point.

This inventorying of resources and forging of relationships, as noted at the outset, turned out to be the real "doing" of Public Humanities at Yale—not delivering the content of our scholarship in new forms, nor simply delivering the academy to the "public." But *evoking* new publics and giving both form and venue to new kinds of collectivity and conversation, and in doing so, delivering the vast knowledge that lives outside of disciplines—knowledge possessed by artists and activists, immigrants' rights workers, community organizers, journalists and filmmakers, poets, musicians, union organizers—*into the university*. One is quickly humbled; better yet, one quickly sheds the arrogance of the institution. The "doing" of Public Humanities turned out not to be primarily a matter of credentialing students or of disseminating the university's intellectual product, but a matter of creating something wholly new in the social fabric that supports such intellectual work in the first place. We have passed on some skills to our students, to be sure, and many of us likewise took an interesting turn in our own scholarly work—in my own case, a turn away from the monograph and into documentary photography and filmmaking. But what the "doing" of Public Humanities has really meant, to take a case, is that on two Tuesdays every month, you can go to one of the branches of the New Haven Free Public Library for a public lecture and a lively, engaged, committed, multi-racial, multi-vocal, multi-generational discussion of "Democracy in Crisis," the kind of collectivity and exchange that barely exists in the United States any more. More than the content of any one of these discussions—on neoliberalism, on criminal justice and policing, on immigration, on white nationalism, on environmental justice—this space of commitment and exchange is itself an exemplar of Public Humanities' achievement.

Somewhere along the way our administration began to like us—not necessarily for the right reasons; rather more as a PR investment on Yale's behalf, but never mind—and we garnered a modest budget for programming, projects, and student support. More importantly, the collectivity of this work (appreciated for the *right* reasons) became a central feature of the culture among the cluster of contiguous and participating units in the humanities. Once you begin the work of cracking silos, it turns out, cracking silos becomes a way of life. In 2014 this spirit of collectivity prompted a series of discussions with likeminded scholars across the region, each representing one of a motley, asymmetrical, but fellow-traveling collection of departments and programs stretching from Boston in the North to Newark in the South. The result was the establishment in 2015 of the North Eastern Public Humanities Consortium (NEPH), whose members include programs devoted to Museum Studies and Material Culture at the Bard Graduate Center; Public Humanities at Brown; the Center for Oral History Research at Columbia; the Futures Initiative at CUNY Grad Center; the Cultural Agents Initiative and the History Design Studio at Harvard; American Studies and the South Side Initiative at Lehigh; the Clement Price Center for Ethnicity, Culture, and the Modern Experience at Rutgers, Newark; Public Humanities at Tufts; Public History at the University of Massachusetts, Boston; and Public Humanities at Yale. This group, now including faculty and students from each institution, convenes annually for three days in April at one of the sites for a series of plenary discussions, student presentations, topical breakout sessions on major issues in Public Humanities, and walking tours, gallery visits, museum tours, and other activities that highlight the distinctive nature and achievements of the hosting institution.

This regional affiliation has generated a great deal of important discussion and mutual support, fostering a generative and enlivening cross-traffic from one institution to the next in the form of teaching collaborations, visiting speakerships, workshops, and the like. One goal of NEPH has always been to augment each institution's resources by drawing upon the others, taking full advantage of our asymmetries. This has worked. But one of the most important things to arise out of this ongoing discussion across several years now has been our group authorship of a Public Humanities "white paper" (sometimes referred to as a "manifesto," which fits), a philosophical document that lays out the *raison d'etre* of Public Humanities, articulates our commitments, and names the field's more general significance for higher education in a neoliberal age. The entire NEPH White Paper is printed below.[1]

*The Promise of the Public: A Social Contract for the Twenty-First Century**

Public Humanities strives to locate, cultivate, and build upon commonalities through broadly collaborative practices of story-telling; of historical inquiry, recovery, and acknowledgment; and of artistic expression, aimed at rededicating the American

university as a true community resource whose public-facing work engenders democratic, civically minded, creative, and just mutual engagements among a broad range of constituencies. For decades we have heard about the "crisis" in the humanities and the bleak future of the non-STEM fields. Many culprits have been identified, from the closed intellectual circuits of increasingly narrow academic specializations; to the highly theoretical, impenetrable prose of the contemporary humanist scholar; to students' concern for utility in a world where a college education might mean a lifetime of debt; to the society's broken bargain on higher education as a highly valued public good.

But the powerful lesson of post-Crash America and the rise of Trumpism is that the public is currently in crisis, and that the humanities may hold out promising answers:

—We suffer a crisis of atomization, in which privatization, neoliberal governance, and an ethos of scarcity and austerity have eroded the very idea of collective destiny upon which broad "publics" are necessarily founded. The humanities generate counter-narratives to this atomization, and the work of community engagement and collaboration creates working networks of genuine community.

—We suffer a crisis of division, in which the intractability of Red State/Blue State animosity derives as much from a paucity of shared information as it does from an authentic incompatibility of interests: the "boutiqued realities" and information niches of the cable and internet era are such that it is not only opinions that diverge and are hotly contested, but underlying data-sets and "facts" themselves. The humanities provide a basis of critiquing, understanding, and addressing this epistemological divide; the convening powers of the university can create public events, projects, and venues to foster communication across such divisions and to recover and rearticulate submerged commonalities.

—We suffer a crisis of confusion and doubt, in which empirical knowledge itself is under assault. Voters in 2016 expressed a disregard for expertise and for settled scientific fact that was shocking to many. The academy has failed to communicate its value as a public resource of knowledge production. While it is the assault on climate and environmental science that many find most alarming, it is the narrative, interpretive, creative, and communicative assets and skills of the humanities that will best serve the university in the public-facing work of restoring confidence.

—We suffer a crisis of amnesia, in which civic discourse on issue after pressing issue has been largely stripped of any deep engagements with our relevant past. The Public Humanities make available such usable pasts from a a variety of perspectives, harvesting local and regional wisdom through dialogic engagements between academics and non-academics, between engaged citizens of different stripes, between different knowledge bases representing very different ways of knowing and of deciphering the past in the present.

—We suffer a crisis of anomie, in which cynicism and desperation disfigure our public culture with spiritual emptiness, lack of imagination, social fragmentation, lack of empathy, outright meanness. Too many individuals are living in isolated despair, while civic structures have become markedly less democratic and have ceased to function as true instruments

of self-governance in a meaningful way. The public-facing humanities re-narrate the basis of our collectivity, resetting the terms of inclusion, and modeling through collaboration what meaningful civic engagement has looked like and can look like once again.

To enumerate the potential contributions of a public-facing humanities is not to present a rosy, utopian vision of all problems magically solved. It is to outline the immense work that needs to be done, and to suggest some intellectual, institutional, and communal tools for doing it. The North Eastern Public Humanities Consortium is dedicated to such work.

Opportunities for the Public

Whether taking the form of museum and gallery installations, documentary work, creative or scholarly work for digital platforms, historical walking tours, and other community history projects, or public programming such as lectures, readings, and recitals, Public Humanities at once embrace and endorse knowledge itself as a public good. While some citizens may have a dim awareness that the medications they take, the technology in their kitchen, or the dramatic writing of their favorite film all derive from the kind of research and training that take place in universities, few who are not themselves students regard the university as an institution central to their lives, and far fewer experience the university as an open invitation to intellectual engagement. Public Humanities seeks to enliven the intellectual and creative life of communities, not only by opening the university outward and thereby expanding its constituency, but by challenging common conceptions of "expertise" and "authority," activating the citizen-scholars outside the campus and cultivating broad public participation in the production and exchange of knowledge. This expanded role for the university not only enriches individual members of the community, but facilitates civic repair by forging new networks for public advocacy and by rededicating the university's cultural capital in partnership with local organizations and institutions.

Opportunities for the University

Though innovative and forward-looking in its interdisciplinarity, its collaborative intellectual spirit, and its expansive modes of inquiry and address, Public Humanities is strangely traditional in its promise to help return the American university to its core mission and founding values. A cursory survey of university mission statements turns up aspirational and praiseworthy phrases like these: "experiential learning through service to others imbues the entire university with a sense of purpose and value in the larger society" (Lehigh); "to serve the community, the nation, and the world by discovering, communicating, and preserving knowledge and understanding in a spirit of free inquiry" (Brown); "committed to engagement with … surrounding communities through teaching, research, public service, experiential learning, free lectures, conferences, and concerts open to the public" (Rutgers—Newark); "committed to improving the world today and for future generations through outstanding research and scholarship, education, preservation, and practice" (Yale); "committed to providing transformative experiences for students and

faculty in an inclusive and collaborative environment where creative scholars generate bold ideas, innovate in the face of complex challenges, and distinguish themselves as active citizens of the world" (Tufts). These are the core values of Public Humanities, and it is our conviction that such programs represent an opportunity for their home institutions to deliver on their most idealistic founding ideas, in a world where overspecialization, disciplinary siloes, a politics of scarcity, anti-intellectualism, and often fraught town/gown relations have worked to diminish the American university's most far-reaching public charge as a community resource and as incubator, catalyst, and democratic steward of the society's intellectual resources.

Tools, Knowledge, Heart, Will

Public Humanities' focus upon democracy and democratic practice is not meant to celebrate and seal a national accomplishment, but to articulate an ideal that has yet to be accomplished. Inclusion is critical to this enterprise—inclusion of the myriad voices that constitute our regional publics, inclusion of non-academics alongside academics in both production teams and audiences, inclusion of complexity in narrating both our past and our present, inclusion of those scholarly methods that do not reproduce biases but challenge them, and that promise to break silences in constructive ways. The most important tools in our kit are the insights of our disciplines, the technologies at our disposal for presentation, and a language that is fully accessible without any loss of sophistication or any concession of rigor.

The knowledge we produce is squarely rooted in the best methods and practices of our professional training, yet it is often more expansive and dimensional for being generated in dialog with diverse partners. In the best instance, we challenge the norms of the gatekeeping function of the modern university as arbiter of what ascends to the status of "knowledge." There is such a thing as vernacular theorizing and wisdom; communities know. This local knowledge is often lost to the university in its capacity as a credentialing institution and in its guild-like guardianship of instructional capital. Our project is not merely to get the work of the university out into the world (though it is partly that, too), but to build new archives, create new paradigms, recover buried histories, and weave new narratives of the sort that can only be produced when guild members cease to speak amongst themselves exclusively.

The ambitions of Public Humanities, then, require qualities of heart and will that have largely eroded within the neoliberal university—an idealism, a vision, a caring, a humanity that have all suffered under regimes of over-specialization, professionalization, pragmatism, hierarchy, and scale within the postwar academy. In what ought to be the watchword of the humanities in general, John Adams once wrote,

> *I must study politics and war that my sons [sic] may have liberty to study mathematics and philosophy. My sons ought to study mathematics and philosophy, geography, natural history, naval architecture, navigation, commerce,*

> *and agriculture, in order to give their children a right to study painting, poetry, music, architecture, statuary, tapestry, and porcelain.*

We join Adams in regarding the humanities as both a social aspiration and a right; our work aims to serve that aspiration, to extend that right beyond the rarified spaces of the university, and in the process to help to transform the university itself into a more able and democratic conveyance of such ideals.

In their radical and radically varied pedagogical work, the authors whose case studies are collected in *Doing Public Humanities* seem to have independently imbibed many of the same principles and arrived at many of the same conclusions: the New Urban Arts mission is "to build a vital community that empowers young people as artists and leaders to develop a creative practice they can sustain throughout their lives" (Smulyan); "the [Rosa Parks] house would become a site for retelling an alternative story of the twentieth century African American freedom struggles," including Parks' own history of activism before Montgomery (Gamble-Rivers, Weinberg, and Bogues); the hyperlocal history represented in The Rhode Tour was "produced by scholars working in local archives, staff at historical societies, and skilled amateur 'citizen' historians..." (Potvin and O'Toole); "eighteen months after the ['What Readers Matter?'] exhibit was taken down, hundreds of people gathered in the atrium of the China Trade Center...to attend the opening of the newly named 'Chinatown Branch'" of the Boston Public Library (O'Donoghue); "Somewhat unexpectedly, the [Against Invisibility] seminar has also been the incubator in three successive years of three projects organized that have lives of their own" (Lee); the execution of Digital Public Humanities has involved "the importance of attending to the materialization of audiences and collaborators as much as it has involved securing resources and expertise to digitize materials" (McGrath). In each instance the site itself and the infrastructure of institutional, intellectual, and personal relationships left in the wake of Public Humanities work is among its most significant achievements. The intellectual *content* of our exhibitions, web-based presentations, documentary projects, local walking tours, or public art installations is of great significance, to be sure. But far beyond "public pedagogy" on the one hand or creating new platforms for the expression of vernacular, community-based knowledge and wisdom on the other, it is this evoking of new "publics" and this laying down of shared intellectual infrastructures that promise most for the *healing* that this moment in higher education most requires: the healing of a social fabric that isolates "knowledge" behind thick walls of "expertise" or loses its wonder amid students' orientation as atomized human "capital," and so has tattered the idealism that is the university's proper birthright.

Note

1 This statement was drafted in a thoroughly collective and enlivening process over a period of some months; its authors include Ryan Brasseaux, Mary Marshall Clark, Kaysi Holman, Matthew Jacobson, Mark Krasovic, Cyra Levenson, Monica Martinez, Najwa Mayer, Seth Moglen, Cheryl Nixon, Diane O'Donoghue, Karin Roffman, Katina Rogers, Susan Smulyan, Doris Sommer, Amy Starecheski, Lauren Tilton, Catherine Whalen, and Laura Wexler. Others may have participated anonymously as the draft statement was passed around in NEPH, and I apologize for their anonymity here.